

and make you question whether they lend to the storyline. Sometimes, there is a proper 3D cutscene and sometimes it just ends up like a comic strip, with static images and dialogues in the background. If you've played the original Max Payne, you'll know what we are talking about except that Battleborn isn't that dark. The confusion doesn't end there, the level design looks bizarrely overdone. There are too many things to destroy and loot. Some levels have pathways over you, below you and some just don't lead you anywhere. Some worlds are bright, full of neon-like colours and some look pale compared to the others.

The MOBA element

The level design becomes even more complicated with the addition of shards. These glowy cacti like things serve as in-game currency, which you are required to collect in order to spend them on turrets, sentry drones and more. Now, in true MOBA fashion, these can be obtained by destroying stuff like shard boxes, exposed shard pieces as well as by killing bigger enemies.

Adding to the MOBA gameplay, each of the 25 characters has a helical skill tree with 10 levels. This does require some getting used to in the match-leve-lling system but once you have familiarised yourself with the gameplay and the characters, these level-ups feel far less intimidating and comes naturally. However, in the heat of the battle, keeping in mind, the mechanics of each character especially with the three abilities, the levelling system can become a little overwhelming.

Furthermore, the FPS style of Battleborn's MOBA element may not go down well with players who like the MOBA genre. All major MOBA titles such as Dota 2, LOL offer an isometric view of your character and the map. It gives you the sense of awareness over the different aspects of the game, such as



MOAR

DEVELOPER

Gearbox Software

PUBLISHER

2K Games

GENRE

Online FPS + MOBA

PRICE

₹999

your teammate's position, enemy's position, game timer (to assess spawn times), cooldown counters and so on. Instead, Battleborn wants you to play the game in split-screen with a friend, which is certainly fun in an FPS fashion but not fulfilling as far as the existing MOBA style of gameplay is concerned.

Mindless killing

This brings us to the actual gameplay of the Battleborn. It is different, repetitive, fast-paced and full of forgetful NPCs. All gameplay modes require you to kill enemy NPCs, it doesn't matter if you are playing a co-op campaign or trying your hand at multiplayer. The storyline is about saving the galaxy, if you care about those things.

Comprised of eight loosely linked missions and three multiplayer modes, Battleborn struggles to maintain a balance between FPS and MOBA. All game modes with the exception of 'Incursion' are filled with objectives which direct you to 'kill this' and 'save that', leaving you with little-to-no free

movement while exploring areas of the map or farming for shards. While you end up pursuing these objectives to clear a particular level, waves of spongy enemies are thrown at you. In Battleborn, all the MOBA style elements, though replicated well, don't add anything noteworthy to the gameplay except for some rare nail-biting moments.

Out of all game modes, 'Incursion' is the only game mode which is able to stand out by offering Quake III Arena style gameplay.

Characters

Previous Gearbox games, especially the Borderlands

franchise, had well-polished characters which the players could connect with. While Battleborns (Yes, the characters are called that only) do not have that same connect, they are still pretty interesting. Unlike any other game we have played in the past few months, the 25 characters in this game offer one of the most unique gaming experiences. Coming from a DOTA 2 background, I felt a bit uneasy and even frustrated initially as I adjusted to the mixed gameplay style of Battleborn. However, once I was able to understand the abilities and experience different characters of the game, I felt hooked. All 25 characters, in true Gearbox fashion, are distinctive, well designed and deliver dialogues which are sometimes funny and sometimes just there to fill in the gaps.

Verdict

Battleborn is a game with an identity crisis. It's too loud and over the top, which might not go down well with either the FPS or MOBA community. The gameplay is repetitive, the story missions lack cohesiveness and the multiplayer mode has no team vs team mode. Having said that, the game is a ton of fun, if you are in for a Team Fortress 2 mashing up with Borderlands. Definitely worth checking out. *